

EAM310 EAST ASIAN MEDICINE DIAGNOSIS I · VUIM SUMMER 2026

Week 3: Pulse Diagnosis

Jonathan Centeno · D.AcHM Candidate · TCM for Ballroom Dancers

Friday, July 25, 2026 · 9:00 AM – 1:00 PM · Prof. Daniel Schrier D.O.M. L.Ac.

⚠️ QUIZ 2 — Thursday July 24 · Eight Principles & Zang-Fu Basics | QUIZ 3 — July 31 · Pulse Diagnosis (next week)

REQUIRED READINGS

FCM Ch. 8 — Pulse Diagnosis	pp. 129–160
FCM Ch. 7 — Tongue Diagnosis	pp. 107–128
CAM Ch. 4 — Four Methods	pp. 127–145
MOA — Pulse sections	ref.
Handbook of Contemp. Pulse Dx	supplement

ASSESSMENT CALENDAR

Quiz	Date	Topic
Q1	Jul 17 ✓	Vital Substances
Q2	Jul 24	Eight Principles
Q3	Jul 31	Pulse Dx
MID + J1–25	Aug 7	Comprehensive
Q4–Q6	Aug 21–Sep 4	TBD
FINAL + J26–50	Sep 11	Comprehensive

LEARNING OBJECTIVES



Locate 6 pulse positions & organ assignments

▶ Describe 胃神根 (Wei/Shen/Gen) of normal pulse

▶ Identify 28 pulse qualities with clinical significance

▶ Execute 6-step palpation sequence

1. Position patient's wrist — palm up, slight dorsiflexion, pillow support

2. Place index finger at Cun (腕横纹 wrist crease)

3. Place middle finger at Guan (桡骨茎突 styloid process)

4. Place ring finger at Chi (尺部)

5. Apply 3 levels of pressure (浮·中·沉)

6. Count rate for ≥1 full minute; assess 9 parameters

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PULSE POSITIONS & NORMAL PULSE

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SIX PULSE POSITIONS — 六部脉 (LIÙ BÙ MÀI)

Position	汉字	Left Hand (左)	Right Hand (右)
Cun 寸 (distal)	寸	Heart (HT) / Pericardium	Lung (LU)
Guan 关 (middle)	关	Liver (LV) / Gallbladder	Spleen (SP) / Stomach
Chi 尺 (proximal)	尺	Kidney Yin (KD-Yin)	Kidney Yang (KD-Yang)

Note: Some traditions assign GB at Left Guan superficial and LV at Left Guan deep; ST at Right Guan superficial and SP at Right Guan deep. Verify with Prof. Schrier's position.

NORMAL PULSE — 胃神根 (WÈI SHÉN GĒN)

Quality	汉字 / Pinyin	Meaning	Clinical Significance
Stomach Qi	胃 Wèi	Soft, slightly slippery quality with gentle wave at middle level	Reflects abundance of Stomach/Spleen Qi; absent = critical prognosis
Spirit	神 Shén	Forceful yet yielding; has "life" or rhythmic vitality	Reflects strength of Heart Qi & overall vitality
Root	根 Gēn	Felt at deep (Chi) level; strong at proximal positions	Reflects Kidney Qi & constitutional essence; absent = poor prognosis

NORMAL PULSE PARAMETERS

Parameter	Normal Finding	Notes
Rate	60–90 BPM (4–5 beats / practitioner breath)	Children faster; elderly slightly slower
Rhythm	Regular — evenly spaced beats	Occasional missed beat in otherwise healthy: may be normal
Depth	Felt equally at floating & deep; strongest at middle	Varies by body type & season
Strength	Moderate force; neither empty nor full	Reflects Qi & Blood adequacy
Shape/Width	Moderate — not too wide, not too thin	Wide = Excess; thin/minute = Deficiency
Length	Fills all 3 positions (Cun → Chi)	Long = Excess; Short = Deficiency of Qi
Tension	Moderately taut — not wiry, not flaccid	Wiry = Liver/GB pattern; Tight = Cold
Smoothness	Smooth flow; moderate slipperiness	Choppy = Blood Xu or Stasis

FACTORS AFFECTING THE PULSE

Physiological

Age · Sex · Body type · Pregnancy · Exercise just prior · Emotional state · Season & time of day

Pathological

Excess → full, rapid, wiry
Deficiency → empty, thin, weak
Cold → slow, tight, sinking
Heat → rapid, full, flooding

Constitutional

"Diagonal Pulse" (斜飞脉) — radial artery courses differently
Inverted Pulse — felt on dorsal wrist; not pathological

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温故知新 · 온고지신

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GROUP 1: DEPTH 深度 (SHĒN DÙ)

Floating 浮 Fú

Exterior Cold/Wind Xu

Feel: Felt at superficial level; diminishes with pressure. Like wood floating on water.
Clinical: Exterior patterns (early-stage pathogen); also Yin Xu with floating Yang

Sinking 沉 Chén

Interior Cold Xu/Shi

Feel: Only felt at deep level; must press firmly. Like a stone sinking.
Clinical: Interior patterns; Cold/Deficiency if weak; Interior Excess if forceful

Scattered 散 Sǎn

Severe Xu Yin Xu

Feel: Floating but irregular; no root; disperses under pressure. Like scattered leaves.
Clinical: Collapse of Kidney Qi; critical/terminal condition; late-stage disease

Hidden 伏 Fú

Severe Cold Extreme Shi

Feel: Deeper than sinking; only felt pressing to bone. Like hidden treasure.
Clinical: Extreme Cold retention; severe pain; syncope; Yang collapse

GROUP 2: RATE 频率 (PÍN Lǜ)

Slow 迟 Chí

Cold Yang Xu

Rate: <60 BPM (fewer than 4 beats/breath)
Clinical: Cold patterns (Excess Cold or Yang Xu); also seen in athletes (physiological)

Rapid 数 Shuò

Heat Yin Xu

Rate: >90 BPM (more than 5 beats/breath)
Clinical: Heat patterns; also Yin Xu (rapid, fine, floating); fever

Knotted 结 Jié

Cold Blood Stasis Phlegm

Feel: Slow rate with irregular missed beats; pauses at irregular intervals
Clinical: Cold obstructing Qi; Blood Stasis; Phlegm accumulation

Hurried / Racing 促 Cù

Heat Blood Stasis

Feel: Rapid rate with irregular missed beats; pauses at irregular intervals
Clinical: Heat obstructing Qi; extreme excess; imminent collapse

GROUP 3: STRENGTH 力度 (LÌ DÙ)

Full / Excess 实 Shí

Excess Heat

Feel: Forceful at all 3 levels; large, strong wave; doesn't yield to pressure
Clinical: Excess patterns; vigorous pathogenic factor; strong constitution

Empty / Deficient 虚 Xū

Deficiency Qi Xu

Feel: Soft, lacking force at all 3 levels; wide but without strength
Clinical: Qi and Blood Deficiency; overall deficiency patterns

GROUP 4: SHAPE / TENSION 形态 (XÍNG TÀI)

Wiry 弦 Xián

Liver/GB Pain Phlegm

Feel: Taut, like a plucked string of a musical instrument; straight, hard
Clinical: Liver Qi Stagnation; Liver & GB disease; pain; Phlegm accumulation; hypertension. Also seasonal in Spring.

Tight 紧 Jǐn

Cold Pain

Feel: Taut and twisting like a twisted rope; harder than wiry; has rotation quality
Clinical: Cold (Interior & Exterior); pain; food stagnation

Slippery 滑 Huá

Phlegm Damp Pregnancy

Feel: Smooth, flowing easily under finger; like pearls rolling on a plate
Clinical: Phlegm; Dampness; food retention; Heat; pregnancy (normal in fertile women)

Choppy 涩 Sè

Blood Xu Blood Stasis Fluid Xu

Feel: Rough, uneven, hesitant; like a knife scraping bamboo; short & slow
Clinical: Blood Deficiency; Blood Stasis; Body Fluid Deficiency; Seven Emotions

WIRY VS. TIGHT — KEY DISTINCTION

Feature	Wiry 弦 Xián	Tight 紧 Jǐn
Sensation	Taut, straight — like a bowstring or wire	Taut AND twisting — like a twisted rope
Primary etiology	Liver Qi Stagnation / Liver-GB disease	Cold invasion / Interior Cold
Secondary	Pain, Phlegm, hypertension, Spring season	Pain, food stagnation
Mnemonic	"Guitar string" — straight tension	"Wet towel wrung" — twisted, harder

SLIPPERY VS. CHOPPY — KEY DISTINCTION

Feature	Slippery 滑 Huá	Choppy 涩 Sè
Sensation	Smooth, rolling, flowing easily	Rough, hesitant, uneven, slow
Substance excess/deficient	Excess (Phlegm, Damp, fluid accumulation)	Deficiency (Blood Xu, Body Fluid Xu)
Can also indicate	Pregnancy (normal); Heat	Blood Stasis (excess but obstructed)

GROUP 4B: ADDITIONAL SHAPE QUALITIES

Leather 革 Gé

Xu Cold Blood Xu

Feel: Floating, hollow, drum-like; firm on outside, empty inside. Like a leather drum.
Clinical: Jing/Essence Deficiency; Blood loss; miscarriage; nocturnal emission

Firm 牢 Láo

Interior Cold Excess

Feel: Deep, wiry, large, long, strong; only felt at deep level
Clinical: Interior Cold accumulation; masses/growths; Yin excess

GROUP 5: LENGTH 长度 (CHÁNG DÙ)

Long 长 Cháng

Excess Heat/Yang

Feel: Extends beyond Cun & Chi positions; felt beyond the 3 positions
Clinical: Excess patterns; Liver Yang Rising; Heat; also can be normal in tall people or robust constitution

Short 短 Duǎn

Qi Xu

Feel: Does not fill all 3 positions; mainly felt at Guan (middle), absent at Cun & Chi
Clinical: Qi Deficiency; also Qi stagnation (excess type)

GROUP 6: WIDTH 宽度 (KUǎN DÙ)

Big / Surging / Flooding 洪 Hóng

Heat Excess

Feel: Surges powerfully under finger; comes strong, leaves weak; like ocean waves
Clinical: Excess Heat; Yang Ming stage; high fever; normal in Summer

Minute / Faint 微 Wēi

Severe Xu Yang Xu

Feel: Extremely thin and weak; almost imperceptible; barely felt even at deep level
Clinical: Severe Yang Deficiency; Qi & Blood collapse; critical condition

Soggy / Soft 濡 Rú

Qi/Blood Xu Damp

Feel: Floating, thin, soft; disappears with pressure; like floating cotton
Clinical: Qi & Blood Deficiency; Dampness (thin but floating)

Weak 弱 Ruò

Qi/Blood Xu Yang Xu

Feel: Deep, thin, soft; only felt at deep level; disappears with pressure
Clinical: Qi & Blood Deficiency; Yang Xu; long-term chronic disease

GROUP 7: RHYTHM 节律 (JIÉ Lǜ)

Intermittent / Regularly Irregular 代 Dài

Organ Xu Severe

Feel: Slow with regular missed beats at fixed intervals; long pause after skipped beat
Clinical: Organ Qi Deficiency (heart, spleen); severe internal disease; also normal during pregnancy or fright

Moving 动 Dòng

Pain Fright

Feel: Short, slippery, and rapid; found at Guan position only; shape like a bean
Clinical: Severe pain; extreme fright; Jing Deficiency with Heat

Racing / Stirred 疾 Jí

Extreme Heat Yang Xu

Rate: >120 BPM (7+ beats/breath); extremely rapid
Clinical: Extreme Yang Excess with Yin collapse; terminal Yang floating

SEASONAL NORMAL PULSES — 四季脉				
Season	Dates (approx.)	Normal Pulse	漢字	Physiology
Spring 春	Mar 21 – Jun 20	Wiry 弦 Xián	弦	Liver Qi rises; Wood element activates; Yang begins to emerge
Summer 夏	Jun 21 – Sep 22	Flooding / Surging 洪 Hóng	洪	Heart rules; Yang at peak; Qi and Blood move rapidly to surface
Late Summer 长夏	Jul 21 – Aug 20	Moderate / Slippery 缓 Huǎn · 滑 Huá	缓/滑	Spleen/Stomach rule; Earth element; Dampness present; digestive Qi strongest
Autumn 秋	Sep 23 – Dec 20	Floating / Hair 毛 Máo (superficial)	毛/浮	Lung rules; Metal element; Yang recedes inward; Wei Qi consolidates
Winter 冬	Dec 21 – Mar 20	Sinking / Stone 石 Shí (deep)	石/沉	Kidney rules; Water element; Yang retreats inward to conserve; Yin dominates

Key principle: Seasonal pulse variations are NORMAL — do not pathologize. A floating pulse in Autumn is expected; the same pulse in Winter may indicate Exterior invasion.

SIX CLIMATIC QI — 六气 (LIÙ QÌ) PULSE ASSOCIATIONS				
Climatic Factor 六气	Pīnyīn	Season	Pulse Tendency	Symptoms to Correlate
Wind 风	Fēng	Spring	Floating, wiry; may be irregular	Aversion to wind, headache, stiff neck, migratory pain
Cold 寒	Hán	Winter	Tight, slow, sinking	Chills, pain, contraction, aversion to cold
Summerheat 暑	Shǔ	Summer	Rapid, flooding, soft	High fever, profuse sweating, thirst, fatigue
Dampness 湿	Shī	Late Summer	Soggy, slippery, moderate	Heaviness, turbid secretions, poor digestion
Dryness 燥	Zào	Autumn	Choppy, thin, slightly floating	Dry mouth/throat, dry skin, constipation
Fire / Heat 火	Huǒ	All seasons	Rapid, full, surging	High fever, red face, thirst for cold, agitation

SHANG HAN LUN — SIX STAGE PULSE GUIDE 伤寒论六经脉证			
Stage 经	Organs	Characteristic Pulse	Key Symptoms
Tai Yang 太阳	BL / SI	Floating (浮 Fú)	Chills, fever, stiff neck, aversion to cold/wind
Yang Ming 阳明	ST / LI	Surging/Full (洪大 Hóng Dà)	High fever, profuse sweat, constipation, 4 bigs
Shao Yang 少阳	GB / TH	Wiry (弦 Xián)	Alternating chills & fever, hypochondrial pain, bitter taste
Tai Yin 太阴	SP / LU	Moderate/Slow (缓迟 Huǎn Chí)	Abdominal fullness/pain, diarrhea, vomiting, cold limbs
Shao Yin 少阴	HT / KD	Minute/Thin (微细 Wēi Xì)	Extreme cold, sleepiness, cold extremities, weak voice
Jue Yin 厥阴	LV / PC	Wiry, rapid (弦数 Xián Shuò)	Alternating heat/cold, Jue (reversal) of extremities, thirst

PATTERN NAME	TCM DX CATEGORY	EIGHT PRINCIPLES
ETIOLOGY / PATHOMECHANISM		ZANG-FU INVOLVED
CHIEF COMPLAINT / KEY SYMPTOMS		SEASONAL / CLIMATIC FACTOR

CHINESE MEDICINE TONGUE MAP

	Left 左	Right 右
寸 Cun HT / LU		
关 Guan LV / SP		
尺 Chi KD-Yin / KD-Yang		

Overall quality: _____ Rate: _____ Rhythm: _____

TREATMENT PRINCIPLE & KEY POINTS / HERBS

TREATMENT PRINCIPLE	KEY ACUPOINTS
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KEY HERBS / FORMULA

